

Reply Handling

Ten kinds of reply. What each one means and what to do about it.

The general rule: reply to anything human the same day. Interest decays fast, and a reply is the scarcest thing your outreach produces.

1. Positive — they're interested

"Yes, we're looking at that." · "What would it cost?" · "Can you come and see it?"

Do: reply the same day. Don't send a price. Ask for a short call or go straight to proposing a walkthrough.

**"Glad to. I'd rather see the space before putting numbers to it — fifteen minutes on site and*

*I can give you a real figure. Would Tuesday morning or Thursday afternoon suit?"**

Don't quote over email. You'll have to pad it, and they'll compare your padded number to someone else's padded number.

2. Neutral — they want information

"What's this about?" · "Send me some details."

Do: answer briefly and specifically, then ask one question back. A generic brochure kills this.

**"We do recurring commercial cleaning around [area] — nightly and weekly. Before I send anything,*

*what would be most useful to know: frequency, what's included, or rough pricing?"**

3. Objection

"Too expensive." · "We're happy with ours." · "Not a fit."

Do: acknowledge, ask one clarifying question, then respond to the actual answer. Don't argue and don't discount.

Most objections at this stage are a request for a reason to feel safe. See **10 Proposal System** for the fuller list.

4. Wrong person

"That's not me — try Dana."

Do: thank them, ask for the introduction, update your records.

"Appreciate it. Would you mind pointing me to the right person, or passing this along?"

Worth more than it looks. A named internal referral is a warm route into a building.

5. Not now

"Circle back in the new year."

Do: pin down a month, then leave them alone until it.

"No problem. Roughly when would make sense — after the new year, or nearer spring?"

A "not now" without a date sits in your list forever. Get the date. Then actually wait.

6. They already have a provider

"We've got someone, thanks."

This is not a loss. It's the normal state of a commercial building, and timing is the whole point of this method.

Do: ask one question and go.

***"Good — that's how it should be. When does that arrangement come up for review? I'll check back then rather than bothering you before."**

The renewal date is the single most valuable thing a "no" can give you. Put it in your tracker, set a reminder for sixty days before, and you have a scheduled future conversation.

7. Unsubscribe

"Remove me." · "Stop emailing."

Do: suppress immediately and permanently. No reply. No "sorry to hear that."

One opt-out list, covering email and phone. Never re-add, whatever happens later.

8. Hostile

Rare. Occasionally someone is rude.

Do: suppress. Don't reply. Don't defend yourself. Nothing good follows.

9. Out of office

Do: pause and resume after the date they gave. Don't count it as a reply.

10. Bounce

Hard bounce — the address is dead. Mark it invalid and stop. Repeated hard bounces damage your ability to reach anyone. **Soft bounce** — full mailbox or a temporary problem. Retry once, then stop.

Two numbers to watch

How fast you answer positive replies. Same business day, ideally within a couple of hours. This is the highest-return habit in the whole system and costs nothing.

What proportion of replies are class 6 — "we already have someone." If it's most of them, your outreach is working and your *timing* is off. Chase triggers harder rather than writing new copy.

What not to do

Don't auto-reply to anyone human. Someone who replies to a cold email is rare. An instant automated answer wastes it, and people can tell.

Don't count "we're covered, thanks" as a positive reply. It's polite, and it's a not-now. If you count it as positive, your numbers will look fine while nothing moves.

Don't send a sixth email. If five touches produced nothing, stop. It won't win the contract and it costs you the chance to come back when something changes.